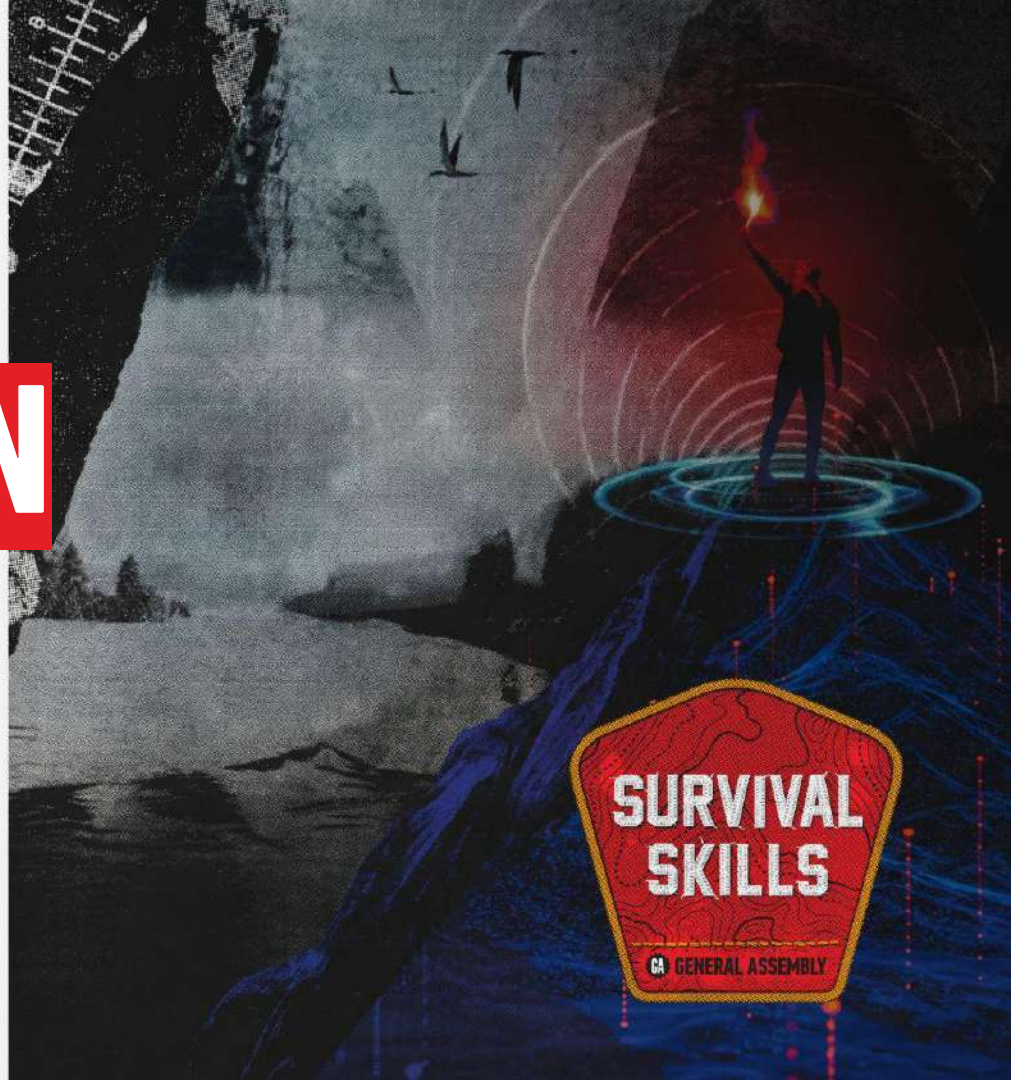
HOW TO STAND OUT IN INTERVIEWS

SKILLS ARE YOUR SURVIVAL - FREE CLASS SERIES



General Assembly

General Assembly is at the **forefront of tech talent development**, specialising in today's most in-demand skills.

We **train and connect diverse tech talent** directly to employers looking to **fill their talent needs.**

CONTENT AREAS

- Engineering & Development
- Data & AI
- Product & UX
- Digital Marketing

FAST FACTS

- **110K+** global alumni
- **25,000+** employees of Fortune 500 companies trained in **20+** countries
- **Flagship campuses** in New York & Singapore + global virtual learning in **over 50** markets
- A brand of the **Adecco Group**, the world's foremost provider of staffing, career transition and talent development solutions.

US Financing Options

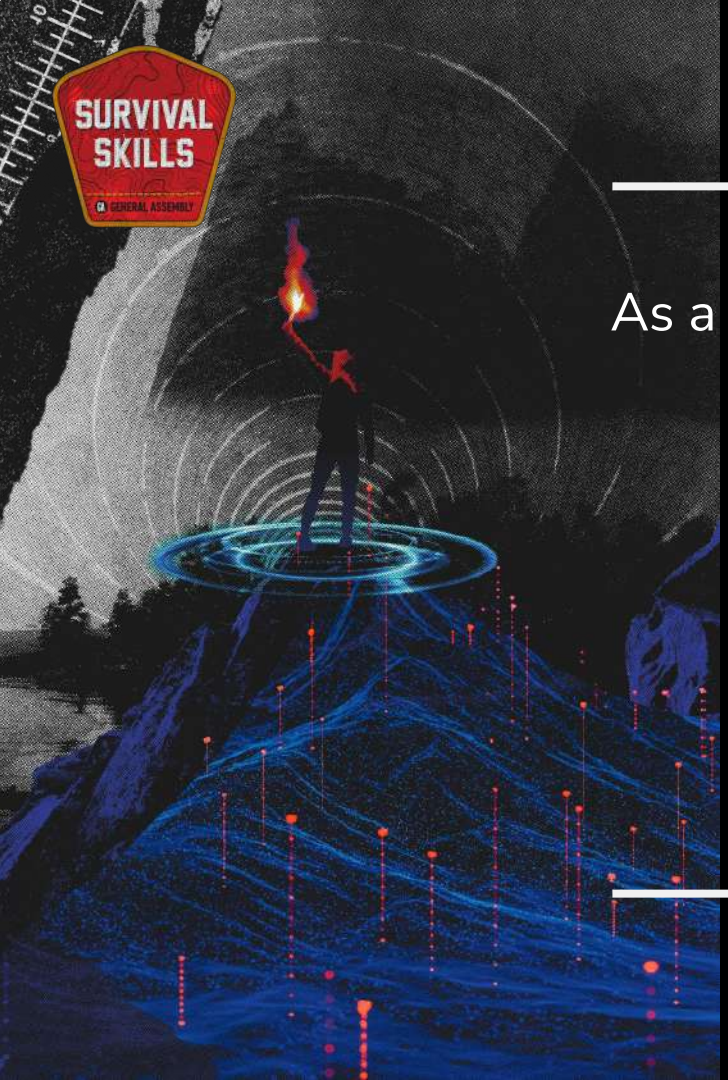
Options vary by region. Talk to admissions to see what you qualify for.

Installments Divide tuition into three easy payments.

Loans Apply for a loan from one of our high-quality lenders.

Full Tuition Save on tuition by paying in full upfront.

Scholarships Our admissions team will help you determine if you're eligible for a scholarship.



As a thank you for joining us today, we're offering:

$25 off a workshop with code Survive26

+ No application fee for new AI courses

Enroll by May 15, 2026

Terms & conditions apply. Discount amount varies based on region and course selected.
Mention Survival Skills when you speak to Admissions to redeem for a course.

Some quick reminders

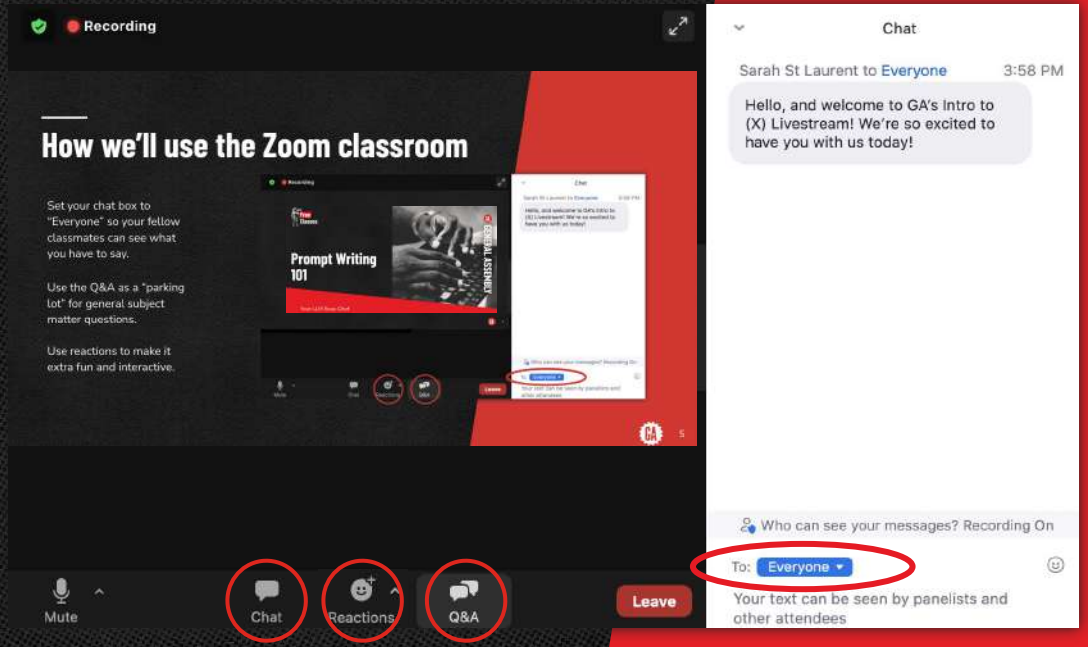
- This is a beginner-level class.
- There will be time for live Q&A at the end.
- YES—we're recording. You'll get the recording from the class via email within 3-5 business days.

How we'll use the Zoom classroom

Set your chat box to "Everyone" so your fellow classmates can see what you have to say.

Use the Q&A as a "parking lot" for general subject matter questions.

Use reactions to make it extra fun and interactive.



Now that we got that out of the way, let's dive in.

What you'll learn today

- Understand how behavioral interviews are structured and what hiring teams are evaluating.
- Use frameworks to deliver effective answers to behavioral interview questions.
- Apply practical strategies to approach a behavioral interviews with confidence and professionalism.

Interview Structure & Preparation

12 minutes

🎯 Key Assessments in the Interview Process

- Professional pitch
- Follow through
- Passion and interest in the role
- Communication / organization
- Experience / qualifications
- Interpersonal skills & takes feedback
- Confidence, poise & clear communication
- Managing conflict
- Emotional Intelligence
- Problem solving
- Culture add

All identified by behavioral interviewing

Advanced

- **End-to-end ownership**
- **Influencing outcomes**
- **Impact & results**
- **Navigating tradeoffs & anticipating risk**

🔄 Behavioral Interviewing in the Interview Process

📞 💼

Phone Screen	Hiring Manager	Technical	Panel	Offer
Quick level & salary alignment: 20-30 mins	Fit & ownership - behavioral & tech questions: 30 - 60 mins	Skills & execution: 30 - 60 mins	Behavioral & tech questions: 30 - 60 mins	Offer details, salary confirmation, start date: 15-30 mins
Should we move you forward?	Can we trust you with the job scope?	Can you do the technical work?	Can we we work with you?	Are we aligned to work together?

🚩 Red Flags

Red Flags

- Rambling or unfocused answers
- Unclear articulation of your experience level
- Inability to connect experience to what's being asked for in the job description
- Giving a salary number too early
- "I'll take anything" energy

✅ Green Flags

Green Flags

- Genuine interest and knowledge about the specific company
- Able to clearly articulate how you're a strong match for the role
- Calm, confident delivery
- Professional curiosity & ask thoughtful questions
- Explain decision making as well as results/outcomes
- Adapt when challenged & reflective

How to Stand Out

Phone Screen

Confidence, company specificity, alignment, prepared not scripted, direct communication

Hiring Manager

Outcomes focused, connect past experience to future impact, demonstrate judgement & ownership, understand team's challenges

Technical

Narrate thinking, ask strong clarifying questions, handle being stuck professionally, reflect at end

Panel

Create sense of good team fit & show capability, answer questions for multiple audiences

REMINDER: PREPARATION BUILDING BLOCKS

PRACTICE

Practice telling your authentic brand story and answers to common questions.

STUDY

Study the job description for which you're applying.

DEFINE

Define what the employer is looking for in your own words.

DRAW

Draw links between your skills and employer needs.

DEVELOP

Develop a new story based on the skills and qualifications that you bring to the role.

Reflect & Share in Zoom Chat

What are some ways to prepare for an interview that you use or have heard are good to use?

Tell Me About Yourself TMAY

15 minutes

TMAY

- **Keep this answer brief.** Usually the first interview question - keep it brisk and lively. **Nothing longer than 2 minutes**.
- **Focus on professional relevance:** 80% based on skills and the specific job description ask, 20% on relevant or interesting personal passions.
- **Don't go back in history too far.** Do not share your life story or regurgitate your resume.
- **Read the "room" and pivot accordingly.** Take notice of moments when the recruiter shows greater interest. This may be a detail to double down on later.

"So, tell me about yourself."

Personal brand statement = good starting point for crafting TMAY answer.

T.M.A.Y. FRAMEWORK

PRESENT	PAST (pre-GA)	PAST (GA Experience)	FUTURE
Plant your flag in the now to start the discussion.	Describe your prior professional life positively.	Build a bridge from past into new career interest.	Express excitement for the new pursuit.
Your title matches the job description. “I am a Front-end Developer...”	Highlight a specific accomplishment / cite specific skills in the job description.	Give a specific example of a project you’re proud of.	What problems can you solve for this specific hiring manager?
Add your focus, specialty, or specific interest.	Clearly explain the “why” behind the move to a new career focus.	Focus in on tech & soft skills relevant to the job.	Tie it all back to this specific company/job.

T.M.A.Y. FRAMEWORK IN ACTION

PRESENT

I'm a Software Developer with a focus on building scalable, accessible products that adapt quickly to user needs. I approach coding as an opportunity to inspire social change through connection.

PAST (pre-GA)

Before transitioning into software development, I led large scale marketing campaigns in the nonprofit sector. This experience honed my ability to consider impact, iteration and stakeholder needs. I worked with CSS and front-end systems and discovered my passion for coding and software development.

PAST (GA)

Recently, I built a full-stack application for a startup, where I owned the front-end architecture and worked closely with a third-party API to deliver a flexible system that could pivot quickly based on client feedback. A core part of my work was addressing accessibility and performance considerations, so the product could scale without sacrificing usability.

FUTURE

What excites me about LinkedIn is the platform's ability to shape professional identity and connection at scale. I'm interested contributing to profile features, where front-end engineering can meaningfully improve how people represent themselves to unlock new career opportunities. I see an opportunity for my technical skills and systems-level thinking supporting that work.

DISCUSSIONS: Solo Activity

Craft your TMAY

- Do a quick internet search to find a **job description** for an opportunity that appeals to you. It doesn't have to be the perfect opportunity, we're just using it for the exercise, as it's easier to craft an answer with a concrete opportunity in mind.
- Outline a **response to TMAY.**
- If writing out your answer word-for-word is helpful, great. Step two is shortening it into **bullet points** so you're not tempted to memorize every word.
- The goal is for a **prepared/strategic delivery** that sounds **natural** and loose.

STAR Method

15 minutes

STAR Method

“Tell me about a time when….”

1) Recruiters use past performance to predict future performance. The “tell me about a time” question is the standard model to help build that understanding.
2) As a framework to craft your answer, we’ll use the popular STAR method as a way to optimize your response, while keeping it focused and interesting.

STAR METHOD: FRAMEWORK

SITUATION	TASK	ACTIONS	RESULTS
Set the scene.	**Describe the purpose.**	**Describe your actions.**	**Share the outcomes.**
Where were you?	What was your role?	What was the process?	Outcome over output.
Who was involved?	What were the goals?	“Why” behind the steps.	Share data measured.
What was at stake?	What did success look like?	Hurdles along the way.	End on learnings/takeaways.
Context + constraints (why this was hard)	*Ownership (what was yours vs shared)*	*Decision logic (what you chose to do or not do)*	*Outcomes + metrics (impact & scale)*

Advanced: STAR+

The + signifies an additional final step: **Reflection-** what did you learn? How has this changed how you work now? Reflection is tied to future behavior.

T.M.A.Y. FRAMEWORK

Question: Tell me about a time you showed initiative on the job.

Answer: Last winter, I was an account coordinator for a major client at an ad agency. Three weeks before a high-stakes campaign pitch, the account executive had a family emergency and was out of the office unexpectedly. There was no clear owner for the pitch.

I proactively volunteered step in as interim lead to keep the pitch on track. I immediately pulled together the creative and media teams, orchestrated an emergency working session, and facilitated alignment on strategy. I led a discussion about ad scenarios and what/why we were recommending and how to sell it.

I drove the group from brainstorming to clear decisions around a cohesive narrative. I achieved team consensus on two priority creative concepts, paired each with supporting media strategy, and clarified who owned which sections of the deck and talking points. I anticipated risk by building a minute-by-minute pitch presentation plan and scheduled a quick rehearsal to ensure handoffs were smooth and the team felt confident to avoid issues.

As a result, we delivered a polished, aligned pitch despite the disruption, and the client selected our campaign. It reinforced for me that initiative involves not only stepping in, but creating structure, team alignment and momentum.

SITUATION TASK ACTIONS RESULTS

DISCUSSIONS: Solo Activity

STAR Method: Practice

- Pull up the **job description** you found earlier.
- Using the **STAR method**, **create a draft** of your response to:
- **“Tell me about a time when a project didn’t go well.”**
- If writing out your answer word-for-word is helpful, great. Step two is shortening it into **bullet points** so you’re not tempted to memorize every word.

- **Advanced prompt option: “Tell me about a time you influenced a decision you didn’t own.”**

Behavioral Interview: What is the Recruiter Looking for?

Tell me about a time when you had to adjust to a colleague's working style in order to complete a project?

What recruiters listen for:
Adaptability, flexibility, ability to reflect on what was learned, team-work, collaboration, communication, etc.

Can you tell us about a time a project dramatically shifted direction at the last minute? What did you do?

What recruiters listen for:
Focus on keeping project on track to meet deadline, comfort in seeking assistance when needed, communication, agility, etc.

Tell me about a time you had to juggle several projects at the same time. How did you organize your time? What was the result?

What recruiters listen for:
Clear, proactive process for organization (to-do lists, confirming deadlines, blocking time, etc.), success in meeting all deadlines, etc.

💬 Answering "Negative" Behavior Interview Questions

This is an opportunity to show that you are self-reflective and aware, have a sense of personal responsibility, and learn from experience.

✅ ***Do***

- Be vulnerable and explain clearly what went wrong
- Explain how you took responsibility and ownership, and what you would do differently next time
- Articulate learning and explain how you apply what you learned currently

🚩 ***Don't***

- Avoid the question by saying that you've never worked on an unsuccessful project
- Blame others or circumstances
- Be self-deprecating or overly self-critical
- Minimize the failure
- Pick a scenario that is catastrophic
- Neglect to share what you learned and would do different next time

Interview Question:

Tell me about a time when a project you worked on was unsuccessful.

Other Questions that May Come Up

No two interviews are the same. Here are some common questions that come up often, that are not **TMAY** questions.

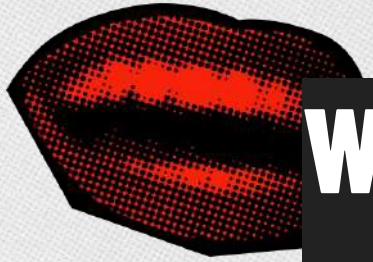
- Why do you want to work here at X company, and why this role?
- What are your greatest strengths and weaknesses?
- Where do you see yourself in five years?
- Walk me through your best project.
- What have you been doing to advance your skills?
- Do you have any questions for me?

Quick Zoom chat poll:

Which of these questions do you feel least prepared to answer well?

Recovery

5 minutes



What if I don’t understand a question?

- Ask them to repeat the question or for clarification.
- Ask for more details or ask questions about the question/situation
- If you’re halfway through an answer, and you can’t remember the second (or even third) part of the question, ask them to repeat it.
- Don’t lie if you’re not sure.
- Don’t be afraid to take a pause before answering - “That’s a great question, let me think for a second.”

Goal: own your imperfection without spiraling. No one is perfect.

Closing Strong & Post Interview

5 minutes

What questions do you have for me?

- Prepare your questions in advance.
- Tailor the questions to who you are interviewing with (i.e. phone screen questions should be basic versus questions to the hiring manager)
- Research the company and ask some questions that show you've invested time in learning.
- If you think of an additional question during the interview, jot it down.
- Prepare your questions in advance and write more than you'll need, as sometimes your questions get answered during the interview.
- In a panel interview, make sure to ask specific people insightful questions related to their departments/roles.
- Be mindful of how much scheduled time is left in the interview and tailor your question amount accordingly.

Post Interview: Write a Thank You email

Candidates have fallen out of consideration simply for not sending a thank you message.

Best practices:

- Send <u>within 24 hours</u> of every interview stage.
- Include every person you interviewed with.
- Re-enforce your enthusiasm for the role.
- Mention why you're a good fit now that you know more about the role.
- Express interest in the next step.
- Mention something specific to the interview so that it's not generic.

Hi Julie,

It was great meeting you to discuss the [job title] role. I appreciated your candid insight into both the role and team, and I especially enjoyed learning more about [project, challenge or priority discussed during interview].

After our conversation, I'm even more confident that this role aligns well with my skills and experience, and I'd be thrilled to join your dynamic team.

I look forward to hearing about next steps in the process. Thanks again for your time.

Best,
NAME

Wrap & Takeaways

8 minutes

After each interview I ask myself, what went well? What can I improve on? That has been a game changer for me + my interview preparation. Most importantly: it empowers you to constantly improve.

-GA Alumni

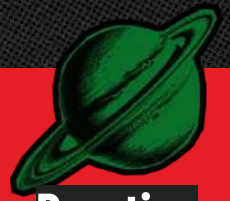
Next Steps to Prepare

Craft a story bank of STAR stories

Aim for 8-10 using the STAR framework. Think about different questions for which you could easily adapt the same story.

TMAY Finalize

Use bullet points to note main ideas. You'd don't need to say the exact same thing everytime.



Practice

Out-loud practice is extremely important for interview prep. Time and effort invested in prep and practice directly impacts results and confidence.

Final Reflection

What's one thing you'll do differently in your next behavioral interview to stand out?

Post your answer in the Zoom chat.

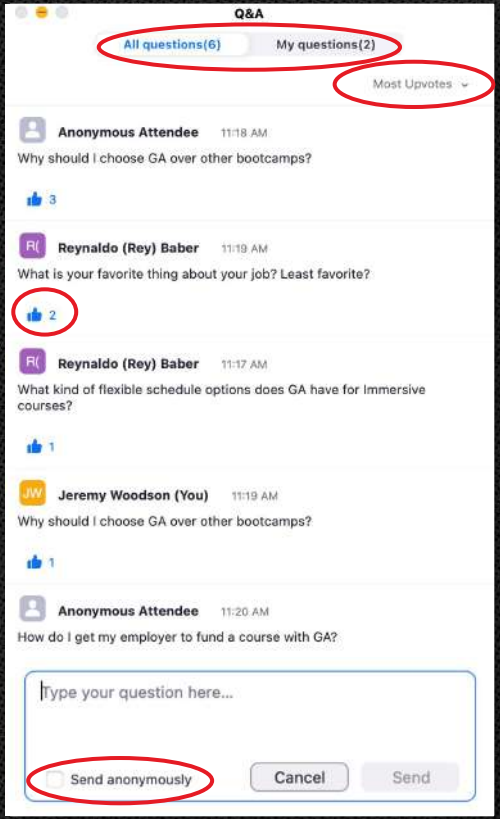
View all questions, or only questions you've asked.

Sort by Most Upvotes or Recently Asked

Already see your question posted? Avoid duplicates and **upvote it!**

Send anonymous questions if you're more comfortable. Otherwise, let us know who you are.

You're up.



More opportunities to learn

UX Research and Strategy with AI

8-week course

Next session:
April 13

AI Workplace Fundamentals

8-week course

Next session:
April 20

Python for AI and Data

8-week course

Next sessions:
April 13
May 5

Let us know what you thought of today's event:

ga.co/skillsfeedback

Thank You

GENERAL ASSEMBLY

Can’t wait to see you next time.